



US Capitol

A new legislative building in the new capital of a new state

When the US became an independent nation in 1783, it had neither a capital city nor a congress hall. In 1790, the Residence Act settled on a site on the Potomac River in Maryland to be the nation's new capital. It was named Washington in honor of the first president, George Washington (1732–1799). Pierre Charles L'Enfant (1754–1825), a French–American military engineer, drew up a basic plan for the city, placing the legislative building on what is now Pennsylvania Avenue, linking it to the President's House. He named the new building the Congress House, but Thomas Jefferson insisted it be named the Capitol, a Latin word associated with the Capitoline Hill, one of the seven hills of ancient Rome.

Creating the Capitol

In 1792, Jefferson proposed a design competition for the new building. Amateur architect William Thornton (1759–1828) submitted a design inspired by the east front of the Louvre Palace in Paris in January 1793. The cornerstone was laid by Washington on September 18, 1793, and the building was completed by 1811.



△ BUILT AND REBUILT

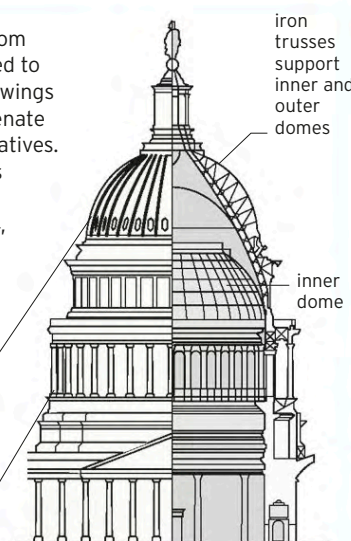
The US Capitol's first dome was made of wood and copper. A new cast-iron dome—featuring columns, brackets, several windows, and a crowning statue—was added in 1855–1866.

EXPANDING THE CAPITOL

By 1850, the increasing number of legislators from newly admitted states led to the building of two new wings to house the growing Senate and House of Representatives. A new central dome was added in 1863, the east front was rebuilt in 1904, and the East Portico extended in 1958.

outer dome, made of cast iron, is painted to look like stone

lower half of drum is surrounded by 40 pillars



In the **early 1800s**, the Capitol was used for **Sunday religious services**